a ‘brave spirit/devil’ a mysterious character in Indian mythology. Last year, he received the Vishisht Seva award 1st class from Nehru himself. That is high merit.

Even if we suspect that the authors, Sun Xiao and Chen Zhibin (both of whom served in the PLA before co-authoring *The Snows of the Himalayas: The True History of the China War*), tailored the quoted conversations, General Yang Chengiou and the Chinese seem to have, in their brief interaction, seen what Nehru and Krishna Menon failed to see for decades. A quasi-political senior officer in the structured confines of any army would threaten its very core. Not surprising then, that when Krishna Menon pushed for Kaul’s induction into the decision-making level at Army HQ, General Thimayya tried to put his foot down. ‘Every sepoy in the Army knows that Kaul has never been a combat soldier. You cannot hide that sort of thing in the Army. The officers do not respect Kaul.’

This sentiment became the rallying point for the Opposition to question the government’s motives in clearing the way for Kaul’s promotion, each time twisting the promotion criteria to favour him at the expense of others. In Parliament, Nehru eulogized Bijji Kaul, saying he was one of the best infantry officers in the army. When J. B. Kripalani, leader of the Opposition, questioned this, saying that Kaul’s only achievement was Op Amar (an operation where the army built houses in Ambala), Nehru countered by saying that Kaul was an officer who had been in the infantry for twenty-five out of the twenty-eight years of his service. He reiterated his confidence in Kaul as ‘one of our brightest and best officers in the army’.

While doors were being opened for Kaul with scant regard to his actual level of competence, both Thimayya and the Eastern Army Commander at the time, Lieutenant General S. P. P. Thorat, had seen the Chinese up close in Korea and had no illusions about their superior fighting capability. The changing equation on the northern border ever since China had annexed Tibet, and the constant friction at the border since 1954 most certainly was of concern to them. Exercise Sheel in 1959 was based on the Western Theatre, where Thimayya had directed the exercise with Lieutenant General P. P. Kumaramangalam acting as the Chinese commander. The conclusion from this exercise was that the available Indian troops and equipment levels were sufficient to contain or even delay the Chinese if they decided to get aggressive in Ladakh.

Around the same time as Exercise Sheel, Thorat forwarded to Army HQ his considered assessment of a likely Chinese attack in Tawang and